Consistent majorities opposed Abe's plans to allow Japan to more easily dispatch forces abroad. For example, in July 2015, just as the Lower House of the Diet was poised to pass the bill, 57 percent of those polled by the *Asahi Shimbun* opposed Abe's security bills allowing Japan to participate in collective self-defense activities.[22] These numbers held steady throughout the period of the legislation's debate and passage, ultimately ending in September 2015, when the Upper House assented to the bills. As the votes were set to begin, tens of thousands of protesters filled the streets near the Diet building, with gray-haired veterans of Japan's pacifist movements joined by students in their twenties, who had no experience of Japan's wartime past.[23] As always, a large proportion of left-wing teachers' groups joined the protests.

Similar controversy plagued the revised alliance commitments. In April 2015, as Japan and the United States unveiled new guidelines for the alliance, a poll by *Kyodo* found that 48 percent were opposed to the new measures, even though fully 70 percent of those polled backed US-Japan cooperation in defending far-flung islands claimed by Tokyo in the East China Sea.[24] In the same month, another *Kyodo* poll found that twice as many Americans, 47 percent compared to 23 percent of Japanese, believed that Japan should play a larger security role in Asia.[25]

In response, scholars such as Keio University's Yoshihide Soeya have argued that Japan must pursue a "middle power" strategy that acknowledges its gross power limitations.[26] Specifically, Soeya believes, Tokyo must embrace a "middle power internationalism" that seeks to maximize Japan's diplomacy and participation in multilateral forums and embed itself in a community of similar middle powers balancing off the demands of the United States and China. Suggestions such as these seek to counter a perceived trend toward "regressive nationalism," in Soeya's words. The belief that the cork needs to remain in the bottle of Japanese militarism more than seventy years after the end of World War II highlights just how strongly Japan's past continues to shape current views.

However, Japanese policy makers cannot shirk their responsibility to prepare to meet the threats they perceive to national security. Public